

outbreak of diseases, ethnic violence, while also mentioning the history, demographics and places worth seeing.

Expedia.com and **Travelocity.com** are the behemoths of online travel planning, but they cater mainly to non-Indian travellers. Check them out if you're looking for information on overseas destinations, hotels and eating joints. However, for working out the cost in Indian rupees and for practical travel tips on how to get visas, passports and insurance, stick to Indian travel portals like **Traveljini**, **Makemytrip** and **Travnova.com**.

Travnova and **Traveljini** talk about popular international travel destinations but are particularly good when it comes to Indian destinations—quick facts, sight-seeing, getting there, shopping, eating out, weather, hotels, you name it—these sites have listed it all. You can browse through destinations by country, state or by interest. For example, honeymoon destinations, beaches, heritage resorts and golf holidays.

If you need more detailed information, drop in a mail to the 'Jinis' assigned to the specific region. Or you could try the 'Travelwizzy' at **Makemytrip** to plan your itinerary to perfection. Some State Tourism Web sites like **www.keralatourism.org**, **www.mptourism.com** and **www.himachaltourist.com** are also a good source of information.

There's more to planning a vacation than getting information on destinations and packages. Travel is about experiences and adventure too. Use the Web to connect with travellers around the world for their views on a particular destination.



Travellers Checks

Payment for online travel services differs according to the type of service you've booked. If it's travel within India, most portals will accept a wide range of options such as international and domestic credit cards, cheques, demand drafts, Net banking, and even cash. The choice, eventually, is yours. For international hotels, car rentals or tour packages, you may have to pay by only an international credit card or in dollars out of your BTQ (basic travel quota). Look carefully for the fine print on additional service charges and extras apart from the published fare on the site.

Feature Comparison for Travel Sites

I need.....	Makemytrip	Traveljini	Travnova	Primetravels	Outlooktraveler	Thomascook
Air tickets	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Hotels	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Car rental	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
International hotels and car rentals	✗	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Destination info.	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Group tours	✓	✓	✓	✗	✓	✓
Visa services	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✓
Travel insurance	✓	✓	✗	✗	✗	✓
Travel finance	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Foreign exchange	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✓

www.virtualtourist.com is an online community of travellers which isn't just about places—it's about the experiences of people who've been there, done that, and who remember it. Each member has

time to visit a particular destination.

Maps are handy travel tools, we all agree with that. So go to **www.mapsofindia.com** to find clickable maps, road maps, rail maps, road maps, as well as tourist



Munish Aggarwal
BUSINESSMAN,
MUMBAI

“We got amazing discounts but there was an unexpected glitch with Traveljini: it gave us vouchers, which some hotels didn't accept, but accommodated us later, after we phoned the portal and confirmed the booking”

a page which they fill up with experiences about the places that they've either been to or are keen to visit. It's possible to record travel preferences, post messages in the forums, and touch base with other travellers using the site's e-mail messaging service. This site has a rating system where you can rank members based on the information they provide.

And there's always Google!

More adventurous travellers who seek off-beat destinations find travel portals very limiting. For in-depth information about places not on the tourist trail, there's no better help than **Google**. This search engine will give you all the information you'd ever need on any destination on earth.

Also, chuck that paper and pencil if you want to make a travel itinerary. Most sites have travel planning tools like itinerary planners where you can save your travel schedule, favourite packages, and keep a record of all online transactions and bookings. You can also use tools such as currency converters to plan your budget and look up the weather to figure out the best

maps of Indian cities and states. For maps of the US and other countries, try **www.mapquest.com**.

The next step: Getting it done

After browsing, surfing, reading, and researching on your destination, it's time to get down to the basic nitty-gritty of travelling—transportation. A couple of years ago, travel portals were good for just information and there was no way you could book a ticket online. This has changed. Portals like **Traveljini** and **Travnova** can get you good deals on air tickets and hotels, so much so that they can even give your friendly neighbourhood travel agent a run for his money.

Gone with the wind

Air tickets are probably the easiest to book online, provided you own a credit card. Most flight search options are powered by central reservation systems (CRS) like Amadeus or Galileo, which formerly only travel agents or airlines had access to.

Online Flight Search options allow